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Reggie Watkins

Trombonist Reggie Watkins has performed with a diverse list of artists, from Maynard Ferguson to Jason Mraz. His recordings as a leader include "Avid Admirer," a tribute to fellow trombonist Jimmy Knepper.

Reggie was interviewed in Utica, NY on May 22, 2018 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are at the Other Side in Utica, New York talking with Reggie Watkins. Welcome.

RW: Thank you.

MR: I'm going to ask a question I usually save, but when you were in let's say junior high school were you having a debate with yourself and/or your parents about what am I going to be when I grow up?

RW: I was having a debate with myself. Because I spent, you know band was important to me developmentally, as it is for a lot of students, musicians coming up through school. And I was in junior high and I was going through a little bit of a misbehavior phase as well because I remember myself and my friend sitting next to me would get sent to the hallway. That was the punishment in junior high, you get sent to the hallway. But at the same time they needed us, because we were the two tuba players you know. And as a junior high student I started getting made aware of jazz you know.

MR: How so?

RW: Basic improvisation from the band director. You know they would maybe play some things, talk about some things, and then give us some kind of basic concepts to learn how to improvise. And I remember going to my friend Matt's house, who was a saxophone player, and doing some things, just trying — you know he had play-a-longs, and so we were checking out the play-a-longs and in band. And I didn't really see myself as a musician actually. And at that school when you left ninth grade that was you graduated junior high in ninth grade. So while you're getting ready to graduate you're signing up for your high school classes. And I left band completely out. I decided I wasn't going to be involved in it any longer you know. And it was the last couple of days of school and I guess that set off an alarm. I got called to the principal's office.

MR: "I didn't do anything."

RW: And so I'm wondering what I did. I go to the principal's office. He says, "So you didn't sign up for band?" I said, "No, I'm not interested. I'm good." He said, "Well I really think you should. They need you." And I think I was showing a little bit of promise in

brought me in there specifically, just him and I, to say, "Look, you're going to have the summer, why don't you do band?" And I said okay. And it was a lie. You know I thought I'm not going to go. So the early August high school band camp commences and I don't show up for band camp. Two or three days later I get a call from the band director. And he basically recruits me. And I don't play tuba anymore and that was part of the reason, I was trying to get away from tuba. But I had shown some promise, went to All-State band and was helpful — I was a needed element to — they needed me there. They need tuba players and they need good musicians. But I just didn't see myself as a musician.

MR: Did they have a marching band?

RW: They did have a marching band. So marching band started early August of my sophomore year and they were like we need to get this guy involved. You know?

MR: Sousaphone.

RW: Sousaphone. That's right. That's right.

MR: I never envied the sousaphone players. I remember watching the bands rehearse. My daughter was in — both of them — in a marching band and carrying that thing around.

RW: Yeah.

MR: But interestingly enough in this spot a couple of months ago we had Joseph Daley, and he was wailing on the tuba.

RW: Joseph Daley, yeah, yeah, yeah. I'm a fan.

MR: Well there must have been some inspiration then, from that point on.

RW: Well it was good that they brought me in the high school, it's nice to have something that you feel like you belong to. Even before classes started I had a sense of belonging to the band you know? And that first year of marching band was really exciting and then it turned out that all my friends were trombone players. So I wanted to be in the trombone section. And there was kind of a light bulb moment where as a sophomore they had a seniors perform for us. Like they brought in all the music kids and they had the high school jazz, the senior jazz ensemble perform for us, and that was that moment. And I'll never forget, the guy's name was Todd. He played lead trombone but he played valve trombone. And everything came together. Like I thought okay, I already know how to play tuba, I know I can play that valve trombone, this can get me out of the tuba section into the trombone section, and at the same time right at that moment I fell in love with the music. And so from that time up until today I've been listening to jazz every single day of my life.

MR: Do you recall what arrangements, what was the style back then?

RW: You know they did a lot of — the band director and the repertoire there was usually stuff like Count Basie, you know repertoire kind of standardized high school jazz repertoire,

of stuff. And that moment, the other component of that experience at that moment was he was improvising. He was taking a solo. And it just had meaning to me. And then ever since then everything I do, and I mean I'm an ensemble player as well, but my kind of my motivation, my fuel for practicing is so that I can exist in the landscape of improvisation you know. But yeah, so that moment, I'll never forget it, I'll never forget that picture there of standing there with all these other students and just having that, that's what I'm going to do. You know? So I never questioned it after that.

MR: Were you more inclined to take risks than other musicians in the band as far as improvisation? I guess what I mean by that, a lot of students are really afraid of mistakes or what they perceive as mistakes. And when they hit one it's like they stop and make a face or whatever. I wonder if that was not an issue for you.

RW: That wasn't an issue for me. And again, I had that background in junior high of having the chance to get an introduction to improvisation and a B flat blues scale, etcetera. So I always enjoyed those broad concepts of A major scale, a B flat, a blues scale, four-four time, like that to me was enough comfort to say oh just go ahead and play you know. And then you learn things as you go along just larger concepts in music.

MR: Right. That little bit of information is a lot of comfort.

RW: Yeah.

MR: I was — when you talk about playing free, that means you have so many choices that sometimes you're stymied. There's too many choices.

RW: Yeah. Free to me means play like yourself. You know. I'm kind of like a music — a lot of us musicians, as I'm sure you're the same, we love lots of music. We have a wide palette. We've listened to things. I get a big kick out of music, just all different kinds of music in the world, but you know, when you're doing something, when they say "free" that means you have license to do whatever you want. So I think your real tendencies come out when you're in the mindset of playing free you know, as opposed to being with, maybe you'll find yourself in a group of musicians that are very specific in their tastes. Okay? So they have what they call "trad" bands in New York City and New Orleans. And I've been to trad sessions in New York City and you go in and everybody's, it's almost like a, like a, it's like you walk into a roomful of anachronisms you know and there's everybody with their old hairstyle with the — the whole thing, the whole ball of wax.

MR: Like a "Twilight Zone" moment.

RW: It really is. It really is. I'm saying wow, they're committed. And then all the musicians are playing, sounding beautiful, no bebop in the language, no R&B into the language. And I really admired that and realized — and it's the same thing if you go to Small's in

bebop factories. And there are people that are very specific in their approach. So for me and for a lot of musicians I think that, the wide range of influences, prevents us from being purists.

MR: And when you put things on your website about what it is you do, you try to make it clear that you're a man with many influences?

RW: Do I?

MR: I think you do.

RW: You think I do.

MR: I mean if you list, when you listed some of the people you've played with, to me it means that you're open to other things.

RW: I am.

MR: As well as the practical idea of taking a gig.

RW: Yes. Absolutely.

MR: I played with Blood, Sweat & Tears. I may have loved that music and maybe I didn't but —

RW: There is a balancing act that goes on as a professional musician, depending on your opportunities and your interests. There are some opportunities I've had which I've had to let go because I just couldn't sign off. You know I don't see a place for me in country music. And I had an opportunity to play with a really big, really big country act, and I couldn't do it. I just — I just thought okay this is crossing the line. And they are great, but you know, so you just make these decisions on a day-to-day basis. But I learned a lot about music and a lot about jazz from pop music, the good kind. And it occurred to me at a certain point that taking a simple idea and giving it lots of love and care, you know, rather than just trying to play as much as you can and play hard. You ever hear that expression? Play hard, play hard. There's a validity to that but, you know, I've noticed like of my old boss, Jason Mraz, he's a songwriter. He's a guitar player. Not in the sense of Wes Montgomery, but in the sense of a songwriter accompanying himself. But just that attention to simple ideas. It means a lot. It means a lot when it comes to getting your point across to an audience. You know. So in improvisation I try to remember that. You know I try to be myself, I try to not be a Bill Watrous, which I could never be. I try to not be — it's just do — my idea is that you take something simple and you nurture it. And if it then grows all these leaves so to speak then that's fine. But at least the start of it is solid and pure and concise.

MR: I like that. Well said.

RW: Thank you.

MR: There's a thing I often read, people describing what improvisers are doing, and it sort of

wondering if how you're feeling, the emotion of that particular day or whatever, affects the way you play.

RW: Yes and no. Because as professionals and as like people making a living you have to block out some of that so that you can focus on your audience. If you can bring emotion, genuine feelings or emotion to the stage it's going to happen in the moment, for me. But if — in a way I don't block the audience out but I don't — I don't know how to explain it but it's like focusing on the task at hand you know. And I want to do it for the music, I want to do it for the people in front of us you know, and then so to carry anything that would come onto the stage that's an emotional thing or a part of my life would just be — those things happen naturally you know. If you have some life-defining event that goes on, well sure, that's really going to do it. But just in a day-to-day we're used to like being tired and being away from our families and everything, and then we come to the music and then the music is its own reward. So then it's time then to enjoy and be a part of the music.

MR: Yeah. Some people like to hear angst in jazz.

RW: Yeah.

MR: I just finished a book about the making of "Kind of Blue." And this author sort of said a number of times that Cannonball didn't really fit all that well in some of the stuff because he was too ebullient. He couldn't suppress his joy in his playing. And I felt like saying and this is a bad thing?

RW: Well at a time when the Mingus, Ornette Coleman, and all these things are going on and yeah, that's like the happy opposite of the political statements. I guess the same could be said for Dizzy in a way, just having so much fun on stage. Yeah.

MR: It goes back to, you were taking about trad jazz. I think that it doesn't rate that high in jazz history or in academia, because it's too darn happy. It doesn't sound like serious enough to study.

RW: Right. And that's debatable. And you mentioned to me before Branford Marsalis. I went to a Branford Marsalis lecture a few weeks ago at the University of Pittsburgh. And it was interesting. He pointed out that he has, you know, a student that wants to play like John Coltrane and is just listening only to John Coltrane. And he said, "How do you think he got to play that way? Do you think he sat and listened to albums of his future self and transcribed it?" He said, "You've got to listen to the people — who was John Coltrane listening to is the question if you want to learn to play like Trane." So you know, he's one of the people that's a firm believer in you have to have those roots before you move forward and to more modern things. And there's a lot of different feelings on that you know. I remember being struck when I was a very young man and had the incredible

together and I had no business being on the stage with Oliver Lake but I was thrilled. And we were tasked to put together a set list. He said to us, he said he didn't know any standards. He didn't know the *American Songbook*. He didn't know things like, just things that you would think a jazz musician would know. But he did know some things like Eric Dolphy tunes and so I don't think he would be somebody, and I might be wrong about this but I wouldn't guess he's somebody that's versed in twenties and thirties music and the big band music of the mid-twentieth century, and even bebop for that matter. I think his starting point is later. And I can respect that because that's the reason he plays the way he plays.

MR: Interesting.

RW: I mean that's the one thing I've learned is that there are some rules but, you know, the opinions are wide. I mean there are so many different ways to go about this.

MR: Let's talk about Pittsburgh for a moment.

RW: Yeah.

MR: I have this — when we started this project back in 1995, I remember someone saying, "Well you should go interview Harold Betters, the world's loudest trombone player." I said, "Really? The world's loudest trombone player." He was a Pittsburgh —

RW: He's still there. We just had a birthday celebration for him. Lots of the trombone players came out, the guys from the symphony, local trombone players, and there's Harold, in his nineties.

MR: Is he still playing?

RW: He's still playing. They just had Slide Hampton in Pittsburgh about a month ago and there they had Harold Betters and Al Dow, another local trombone player in Pittsburgh, who is one of the first people that allowed me to come up and sit in and be receptive to us. We couldn't play you know. I'm from Wheeling, West Virginia originally so the big city to us was Pittsburgh. We would drive up, go to Al Dow's jam session and then drive back to West Virginia you know. And Al would let us on stage. He would welcome us into the community. But Harold, yeah, so they just had Slide there and Peter Lynne, are you familiar with Peter Lynne the trombonist? He plays trombone. He helps Slide. You know Slide had a stroke not long ago so he helps Slide with some things, some physical things and also some musical things so they brought them out to Pittsburgh for the show, and he did a great interview of Slide and Harold. This was just a month ago so you can find that on line, there's Slide and Harold talking about each other sitting next to each other.

MR: Yeah. That's a great thing to capture.

RW: And Harold said, "I could never play fast like these guys so I just play melodies." And Slide said, "I couldn't play melodies, so I just played fast." Just to see the two of them sitting there, it was great.

MR: That's terrific. Most musicians it seems have a moment that they figure I have to go to New York. Was that true for you?

RW: Yeah it is in a way, it is in a way you know, but you know my first goal was the make a living playing music. And so I got out of college. Well first of all I was in college I had a great mentor, a relatively unknown bassist and composer, Kevin Friesen.

MR: What's his last name?

RW: Friesen. Like David Friesen. No relation, but Kevin Friesen. And we were kind of in his camp. And he was serious, meaning a 10 p.m. to 8 a.m. rehearsal was not uncommon for us. So ninety percent of people that came through the door in his scene left immediately because he was too rough around the edges and it was too much of a commitment just work-wise and emotionally for a lot of people. But so I stayed. I was drawn to him and he was of course, he opened my mind up to everything: avante garde, he had thousands of records, incredibly versatile on electric and upright bass. So that was a real education. And I left there to go work on cruise ships. Then I went to Pittsburgh. I grew tired of the ships. Inside of two years I was done. So I made a little money, I got out, learned a lot of standards during that time, which was good.

MR: Learned how to be punctual.

RW: Learned how to be punctual. Learned how to front a band. Learned a bunch of standards without the internet and real books or anything. Nineties.

MR: Okay. How did you learn them if you didn't have the internet.

RW: I'd have older guys show them to me. Because when we came onto the ship, I remember the first ship I came onto in a quartet, the other band was guys that, they knew a million tunes. And they were thirty, forty years older than us. So they would be a resource. They might have — I remember that guy having a stack of real books but we didn't have that. He had a stack of real books. So that was one resource. But also you could just catch them after their set, because I would figure things out and say, "Hey what's the bridge to" such and such. And they would just show me you know. So I left that and I went back to Pittsburgh and started doing my thing there. And my idea was to go to New York. I had friends that were moving to New York. But keep in mind I'm from Wheeling, West Virginia. So I was thrilled to get that cruise ship gig. You know there was a big possibility in my mind that I would never get out of West Virginia. So I got, the thing that helped me to move to Pittsburgh was I got a gig with a cover band so I could move to Pittsburgh. And then I started to come on the jazz scene. Roger Humphries, who is the

an amazing drummer. So I'm getting just all this experience there. And then Maynard Ferguson would always have young guys in the band. And where they were from, it kind of moved like a wave. So if you had a lot of guys — if there were guys in the band from North Texas then they would recommend their buddies from North Texas. So there were some guys that got on to the band from Pittsburgh. And that began a wave, and then I got recommended onto the band and I subsequently recommended other people onto the band. So finally I was involved in jazz. So going with Maynard in 1999, by a year later I was musical director. And it was really worthwhile to me. I could write, I could play, I could meet other musicians, do record dates, go to New York. My experience in New York when I was with Maynard I would go to New York and live there for a week and play the Blue Note you know? Or go into the studio. And that happened a lot. It was the same thing with London. We would go and play Ronnie Scott's for a week or two weeks, and these different places. And Seattle, Jazz Alley, Blues Alley, you know, all the different jazz clubs we'd go there for a week and we'd do it year after year. So that prevented me from moving to New York.

MR: Because you had the income, you had the gig and you had the travel.

RW: I had the connection to jazz you know. And I thought it was good work. And it didn't pay that great so there were a lot of slightly more established musicians that wouldn't do that gig.

MR: It paid what?

RW: It didn't pay that great.

MR: Yeah. Was it a salary?

RW: Salary.

MR: So it didn't depend — if you only worked twice in a week you were getting a salary.

RW: Which that never happened but yeah. Yeah you got a small salary. But they would give raises from time to time depending on who was asking. And then also I had the — Maynard wanted me to stay towards the end of my time with him, so I did a record, my first record. I was allowed to open the show for him, sell my CDs, again, this was just slightly before the MP3 download thing got really big. So I was selling CDs after the show for twenty dollars a CD. So by the end of my stay I was actually doing pretty well with this band, which was thought of as a low paying job you know. So Maynard passed away in 2006 — well let me say this again. Let's just rewind a little bit. Kind of halfway through that experience a friend of mine said — one of the guys on Maynard's band — said, "Hey do you know what the Thelonious Monk Competition is?" I said no. He said, "This year it's in trombone. I think you should audition." I was like really? He was like, "Yeah, I think you have a shot." I'm thinking me? You know. So I put together a tape

became aware of what else existed out there. Andre Hayward won that competition. I met — re-connected with Andre there, re-connected with Steve Davis, Elliot Mason was a competitor, Marshall Gilkes, all these great trombone players. And the judges of course: Grachan Moncur, Julian Priester, Steve Davis, Curtis Fuller, you know. And then of course Herbie Hancock is there, Wayne Shorter is there, all the Monk Institute people. So that was a time for me when I thought wow this is, now I'm getting a view of what's really going on you know. I didn't feel like I belonged there at all but that was the first sense I got for what was happening. After Maynard died, two years after that I got the call to go with Jason Mraz, and that was something I couldn't turn down. And that lasted a long time. And also New York, I kind of missed my opportunity — my father lived to be 92 and as he was aging I thought it's bad enough I'm on the road, I want to go home and check on him, and I didn't want to disappear from the region completely so just choices were made and that time between 2006 and 2008 I would — you can ask my wife, I would go to New York once a month on a bus and sleep on my friend's couch, go to sessions and hang out, yeah.

MR: It's always a weaving path for musicians. Do you have an idea of what it means for yourself to "make it" in the music business?

RW: Well you know for me making it is doing what you want and getting paid. Not just doing what you want and not getting paid. So — because we could do that. I could do that until the end of time in my living room, but yeah, being able to do things that you enjoy and making a living from it. And you make compromises and that's okay. That's what life is about you know. So you know I have some different things that I do and over time you come to accept where the music is taking you.

MR: If a junior high trombone player saw you play and then came up to you and said, "I want to do what you do." And his father and mother were standing behind him, do you have advice for that student?

RW: Practice, practice. And stay in school. You know I had a student come to me when I played with Maynard Ferguson in Pittsburgh. Those were always great shows. And his name was Frank Cohen. He walked up to me and said, "I would like to have lessons from you." I think he was in tenth grade at the time. And he said, "Oh I'd like to have lessons from you." And I said, "Great, let's do it. When I'm off the road let's get together." So we started getting together. And you know, I don't see myself as like a teacher in the traditional sense. I'm a suggester. You know? I like to practice with my students, give them suggestions, give them different ways to think about things, and help them go through the process. But so we did this. He was coming to my house with his dad for lessons. And his question to me when he was getting ready to graduate from high school

a university in Pittsburgh. He was thinking about his options in the region. I said, "Frank, apply to all the best jazz schools on the east coast and just see what happens. He went to the Manhattan School of Music and got a master's degree. And Frank has several Grammys now. So my advice to him was move to New York. And he did. And he's doing all this great stuff. And I'm really proud to know him and I'm glad I gave him that advice. Not that he couldn't have had another path to happiness but it was great to see him go there and succeed and I thought yeah, again, to your question of myself being in New York, I thought now's the time if you can go to New York you should go. And he did and he's done very well.

MR: Great. Let's talk about composing. I'll try to do this, a name this tune [scats] that was very bad. [piano] Right, but that's not what I meant to say.

RW: No? Try again?

MR: This is one of your things.

RW: This is one of my things. Give it to me again.

MR: [scats] Then when it comes down it's minor. It's on your website and it's called "Chala Nata"

RW: Oh "Chala Nata." So that's not my composition. But that is from my second record called "One for Miles One for Maynard" — two of my biggest influences. Miles, purely as a listener I was influenced and he was an idol of mine, and of course Maynard being my boss and somebody influencing me on a daily basis. Maynard loved to talk about India. And Maynard during a certain period of his life, his seventies, sixties I think it started. And a lot of people don't know this about Maynard. You know Maynard lived with Timothy Leary. Did you know that? And his entire family.

MR: I didn't know that.

RW: But he would go to India once a year for several months to an Ashram of a guy named Sai Baba. They called him Sri Sathya Sai Baba and he was a spiritual leader. Maynard loved Sai Baba. He would go there, you know as he would say, once a year for six weeks or two months where it would be a cultural exchange. He would teach music, jazz, and then he would learn Indian music. He loved Indian music. So "Chala Nata" was a product of him wanting to have something in the repertoire — and that's not the only thing, there were other tunes like that that were Indian-flavored, Indian jazz fusion stuff [piano].

MR: That's what I was trying to sing.

RW: So that was my tribute to Maynard Ferguson. I knew how much he loved Indian music and I love that chart.

MR: Yeah. I like the way it starts out like sort of ethereal.

RW: Yeah. And very seventies.

RW: It's absolutely — the jazz part of it or the American take on it is very seventies popular music.

MR: Right. And then even when the drum thing starts it's very boo-ga-loo-ish.

RW: [Scats] that kind of like Ringo Starr almost. Yeah. So I wanted to do an updated version of that. But it's not my composition. The composer of that is Jay Chattaway.

MR: Oh. A familiar name, yeah. So if I commissioned you to write a chart, let's say for a ten piece band, anything you wanted. How would you approach that? How do you get started?

RW: Well I the starting point has to be — well anything I want then I would think well who am I? What do I really want? And the first thing would be the instrumentation. So if I could do whatever I wanted, it doesn't have to be a college big band. If it's a ten piece band it could be anything, right? It could be two drummers. So I would think a lot about the instrumentation. I would also think about some of the musical compositional ideas that I have that are kind of on deck to be set into something more complete. Because I have a lot of ideas, I think a lot of musicians do. Snippets. Compositions. Parts of compositions. Movements of — so I would look at what I already have. I would think about something, you know, maybe something that's brand new but instrumentation I think is a good start.

MR: And where does the initial melodic idea — do you stumble across those things? Do you vocalize them? Do you sit at the piano?

RW: All of the above. I get — in the morning I typically get these flashes of tunes, they feel fresh. If they feel fresh they're fresh. You know, maybe twelve hours later you say ah it's been done before. But if it comes across and feels fresh I'll record those little ideas and I'll think about them and think about them and try to let them grow you know. I have other songs, I have sections of songs where it's like introducing, it's like playing matchmaker. Introducing — oh, have you met, have you met? He's in the same key as you.

MR: Would you get along?

RW: He's 24 bars, I know you're 16 bars but —

MR: That's clever.

RW: You guys would be very compatible together.

MR: That's a good answer. So Jimmy Knepper. It's nice that you paid attention to him like you did because there's an awful lot of musicians in sort of that middle ground that as time goes by they don't get the recognition. So that was a very passionate excursion for you.

RW: It was, because how it started. Are you aware how this started?

RW: His daughter and my mother, his wife and daughter and my mother went to the same church. My mother still goes there. It's a Unitarian church. And yeah, so they were friends. My mother was good friends with Jimmy's wife, whatever. But anyway, time moved on and she passed but Jimmy's daughter Robin was still there at the church with my mother and my mother — it just kind of came together and my mother, "You know who Jimmy Knepper is?" "Yeah, of course I know Jimmy Knepper." His daughter goes here she has some mouthpieces for you, she's wondering if you wanted them. And I reached out to her and kind of didn't hear back and then my mother circled back a while later and said, "Hey, Robin's talking about maybe giving you Jimmy's horn." So I connected with Robin. Jimmy Knepper died in Wheeling, West Virginia, where I grew up. Because that's where Robin and her husband were living at the time. So when they had to leave Staten Island because they were getting old, you know, he I think eventually developed Parkinson's. They cared for them in Wheeling, her mother and Buck. So that's how this all kind of came together. So when this is a few years ago Robin decided it was time to pass along Jimmy's physical things — the horn — it meant a lot to her even because she associated so much with him. And she is just this beautiful person. And when I went down there to see her as they're getting ready to move and they're getting their place in order and getting it ready to sell. I walk in and there's like nine trombones and a trumpet and some other things on a bed, and mouthpieces and mutes and all this stuff. She gave me a horn. She gave me several horns. And it was so profound. I shared all this with my good friend and collaborator Matt Parker. He's a saxophonist from Brooklyn. And so we started working on this tribute concert for Jimmy Knepper and we just went in all the way, Jimmy Knepper, and we realized it was like even more than what we were aware of. Of course we know about the Charles Mingus work, and he's kind of framed in that world as like a copyist. But then again he's also, if you dig a little deeper you'll see that he's included as one of three of the most important contributors in Mingus' career. Danny Richmond, Eric Dolphy and Jimmy Knepper. So we went and did this big concert and it was sold out. It was in Wheeling at the Stifel Fine Arts Center, and Robin was there. And it was really, that was all it was. And she, I'm just telling you the emotion, the love and the feeling that is just around her — and I have a daughter so I'm seeing this woman, who is twenty years older than me, I'm seeing her as a little girl. I'm seeing her as my daughter. And so all this experience is touching me on another level. And then after that happened another bass player from Pittsburgh, who executive produces a lot of records, his name is Mark Perna, he showed some interest in supporting us for a record date. So then we were like wow, we're going to make a record. So then we got to go even further into the Jimmy Knepper legacy. And then we got to share those

heaviness in Jimmy's work. So just the whole experience was unbelievable. And I was just caught in the wave you know. I had only known Jimmy — I never had a Jimmy Knepper record, maybe one. I had all the Mingus stuff because I'm a Mingus fanatic so I had all the Mingus stuff but — so it brought me really close to him as an artist.

MR: Terrific. When you do a record date like that how much time do you get in the studio?

RW: It depends on your funding. It depends on your funding. So I did two days. Everything for that was preparation and getting the charts in order, rehearsing, and then going into the studio, kind of a pricey studio, you know, in Brooklyn, so we were two days in the studio. And that was enough.

MR: Does it take a while to get used to the fact that there is some separation in the studio, the drummer may be behind a glass house or whatever.

RW: It does.

MR: And you've got headphones.

RW: It does. In that studio, although we could have been completely separated, we purposely didn't do that. So like the bass player was in a booth but the door was open and he was kind of out. Piano was out in the open, horns were facing piano and drums. Maybe the drums had a little bit of soundproof. But we were all looking at each other right here. You know. So it was somewhat live.

MR: Is everybody involved, all the players, are they all involved in the choosing of the best take?

RW: Yes. Well people can weigh in. But when the session is over you still have two or three takes of each tune that, you know, the buck stops with whoever is producing the record. So we had to eventually —

MR: Make that choice.

RW: Yeah. So we had a lot of material to go through, and there was a lot we didn't use you know. Because we probably recorded fifteen, sixteen songs, several takes.

MR: Wow. That's a lot.

RW: And we wanted to go with — for a long list of reasons you pick what you pick you know?

MR: I mentioned earlier, you went into trad jazz clubs and so forth. If you could do time travel would you go back to a certain era to witness particular jazz events?

RW: Hmm that's a good question. I think I would go ahead and do the 1959 thing you know.

MR: I just read something about 1959.

RW: Yeah 1959 was big. I think I would probably do 1959. Just drop me off in New York and just let me — I'll figure it out you know.

MR: You sometimes wonder — did those musicians have a sense that what they were doing

RW: I think they did.

MR: Yeah?

RW: Because if you look at some of those old clips of shows where they're introducing — of course the musicians were celebrated to a certain extent. On the other hand of course horrible discrimination and whatnot was going on in our country. But artistically they were being validated not only by their peers but by the media and by listeners in other countries. And if you were a jazz musician in the fifties and you went to Europe you would feel that sense of appreciation. You know, that maybe you aren't getting in the United States. But I think a lot of them knew. You know you see — Duke Ellington lived long enough to understand that he was not just a successful band leader and composer/arranger, but also celebrated as a national treasure. I mean a lot of the things that were said about Duke Ellington were said while he was alive. You know, greatest American composer of all time. That kind of stuff. Some of them knew.

MR: I've seen many times the phrase jazz is America's only original art form. And I sort of agree but then I think well what about the blues, and if we're calling rock & roll art now, I guess what I'm trying to say is it's wonderful that so many forms of music started here and then got spread around the world.

RW: Yeah. Terms are tossed around quite loosely. "Artist" — there's a loose definition to that. And the African-American experience is so unto its own. You know this experience, in this country, created everything you're talking about: blues, rock & roll, jazz, it's all part of the same experience. But I know what you mean, they make the distinction that jazz is an art form, the only true American art form because blues and rock & roll and the other things were thought of as popular music and jazz is thought of more as an art music.

MR: But jazz was popular music when it started.

RW: It was. It certainly was.

MR: Yeah.

RW: And the categories, and rock & roll has broken all the boundaries and definitions and borders as well. I mean have you heard — there's so many sub-genres in rock & roll, and there's some incredible things that have happened. I don't know a jazz musician that doesn't respect the work of Zappa you know. I love Bjork. Now what is that music? You know? But yeah, jazz as an art form — I mean I hear all the time too, I don't know how true that is, I don't know how you define art, but I hear that quite a bit.

MR: You're playing tonight in this space. You're playing with a musician you know really well. You're also playing with musicians that I don't think you've met. And this is not uncommon in the jazz world. Sometimes you get a gig then you get a band. But sometimes people are mystified by that. If someone who really likes jazz but doesn't

understand how that's possible, they say, "How does that work? How does jazz work like that?" Can you respond to them?

RW: I think it's good to compare it to the rules of a conversation and a language. As you and I are here having a conversation there's a certain — we've learned, we met today and we've been learning to speak our entire lives this language, so that we can have a conversation. We can have a deep and meaningful conversation. And it's like that in jazz. There's nouns and verbs, pronouns. I mean there's sentence structure. So there's a language. It's a broad language as is a spoken language. So that would be my best way to make a non-musician understand what's going on there. There are things that are unsaid because we've all studied the language. And it has to start somewhere. My four year old son is learning to write his name you know, and that's going to turn into him having hopefully one day a mastery of the language.

MR: Has he learned the word "gig" yet?

RW: Oh yeah. He knows when dad's putting on his gig shoes. My father was a minister so it was church shoes. But for me it's gig shoes. Yeah. But yeah so there's a language there. Now when you have deeper relationships, you know, you can have more intimate, meaningful conversations. Of course I think the relationships are invaluable, when you talk about bands and regular relationships between people. Time counts for a lot you know. So I can have a great conversation with you but it's not the same conversation that I could have with my mother, you know, or somebody that I know more. So yeah it's interesting to see what'll happen. I've got Mike — Mike and I were on the road, Mike Dubaniewicz and I were on the road with Maynard for years. And then Orrin and I are close. But the other guys, we'll see how it goes. We'll speak the language.

MR: Yeah. And sometimes when there's a potential train wreck in the music it recovers nicely and it becomes like a thing.

RW: Yeah. Mistakes are good.

MR: Mistakes are good. You played, I don't know how long before, but you played with one of my favorite bands, with Blood Sweat & Tears.

RW: Um hum. I spent about a year.

MR: How did you learn that music? Did they have the charts and all that?

RW: They sent me the charts.

MR: Yeah. Were you expected to memorize them?

RW: I was expected to get a grasp on them and be ready for the gig. Some of the other guys had sheet music on music stands. I in a lot of situations will put music onto my iPad, so and with this software where it's for reading music off of an iPad. So I did a lot of listening, looking through the parts.

RW: No. He was not — this was just like around a year ago.

MR: Oh okay.

RW: So I was subbing onto that band. I don't know if I did eight or ten gigs with them. The musical director at the time was my old friend from Maynard's band, Carl Fischer, who is now a featured trumpet player with Billy Joel. So he left his position with Blood, Sweat & Tears and he's got plenty to do with Billy Joel and other things. But yeah, so that was — I appreciate those kind of experiences.

MR: Like with Postmodern Jukebox?

RW: Yeah.

MR: You're going on tour with them?

RW: Yeah, an on and off tour, yeah. Speaking of trad bands.

MR: Yeah. What's their thing, new music, old style.

RW: New music vintage style.

MR: Vintage style.

RW: So they've got that down.

MR: Yeah. That's a good niche these days, it seems to be a good niche.

RW: That's their niche and people really respond to it. I saw Branford and I was talking to him and we have a mutual friend, Chris Hemingway, who I was on the road with with Postmodern Jukebox. And I said, "Hey I just got off the road with Chris Hemingway." He goes, "Oh Postmodern Jukebox, I love that band." I didn't expect for him to say that you know.

MR: Okay. Let's wrap up with what do you think of the state of jazz education? Do you have an opinion?

RW: I think it's good because there's always a new crop of young people that are willing to commit to the journey. And they're looking to be educated not just in institutions but in the experience of having mentors and real life, you know, experience, gigs. That's where you really learn. You learn a lot in school as well and I think it's great when I think of people like Sean Jones you know, now going to Peabody. And I hear the young people playing that are very good you know. So I think we're in a great space. I don't like to demonize — everything has its place. The school thing is the structure of school. There's a lot to be learned there. But as a player, having that experience either as a fly on the wall or if you can actually make it onto the bandstand, being there to see the real thing is the most important as a player.

MR: Good. Well I'm looking forward to hearing you tonight.

RW: Thank you.

MR: And best of luck with your tours and your trombone and your children.

MR: All right. It's been a pleasure.

RW: My pleasure. Thank you.